



straight-game defeat to China's eventual finalist He Bing Jiao did not come as a surprise. But it may be recalled that Sindhu defeated the same opponent to clinch the bronze in Tokyo.

A quick look at the last three Olympics reveals a medal from each edition in women's singles. Saina Nehwal (bronze in 2012 Olympics) and P. V. Sindhu (silver in 2016 and bronze in 2021) kept the Indians interested longer than their male counterparts.

Though Sindhu was around without promising much in Paris, the duo of Satwik-Chirag was considered a medal favourite.

They warmed up for the battles ahead with easy wins in the league stage to move to the quarterfinals. Seeded to be on the podium, the third seed ran into the unpredictable

and experienced duo of Aaron Chia and Soh Wooi Yik.

The Indians played to their form in the first game to close it at 13 in just 17 minutes. There was a twist in the tale in the second when the Malaysians bounced back from 0-4 to win five successive points. This spell injected an immense self-belief in the unseeded pair. The Indians tried to catch up, but in vain. In the decider, Satwik and Chirag looked in control at 11-8 and 14-11 to lead until 16-15.

Thereafter, in a dramatic turnaround, the Indians' defence fell to pieces and the relentless Malaysians raced away with the final six points in a flash to leave their opponents stunned.

The performance of Ashwini Ponnappa and her younger rival Tanisha Crasto was on expected lines. This pair lost all three group

Maximum effort: Lakshya Sen came the closest to handing India another medal in badminton. RITU RAJ KONWAR

matches in straight games.

On the brighter side, a touch of saving grace came from an unexpected quarter. Lakshya, World No. 22, kept punching above his weight, eventually reaching the semifinals.

Lakshya started his maiden Olympic campaign with a straight-game victory over Guatemala's Kevin Cordon. However, Cordon withdrew after this match and thus the result stood nullified. Lakshya went on to beat Belgium's Julien Carraggi, also in straight games, to set up the match to decide the qualifier from this group to the pre-quarterfinals.

Indonesia's Jonatan Christie, seeded 16 – against Lakshya's 19 – started as the ranking favourite. But Lakshya settled down early, played some amazing strokes, and kept the rallies going when on the defensive and produced some clinical finishing shots to win 21-18, 21-12 in just 50 minutes.

In this match, Lakshya trailed 2-8 and 16-18 before reeling off the last five points in a hurry to claim the first game. After the early exchanges in the second game, Lakshya repeatedly pounded his rival with measured jump smashes on either flank, kept his net-play consistent and broke Christie's belief to win much before the match reached the home stretch.

The 39-minute victory over Prannoy, the scoreline being 21-12, 21-6 ensured that Lakshya was not stretched before the quarterfinal clash against Chinese Taipei's Chou Tien-chen, seeded 12.

Having taken out the third-seeded Christie in the group stage, Lakshya was not expected to meet a player any higher till the semifinals.

Against Chou, Lakshya kept his cool despite dropping the close first game at 19. He believed his game was getting better and proved it for a vociferous group of Indian support in the arena over the next two games.